3

From Exceptions to Cases of a Participatory Budgeting Phenomenon

In the development of our understanding of PB as a successful democratic innovation, first steps towards examining multiple cases came in the form of early comparisons of carefully selected cases of PB. While studies of individual cases in Brazil and beyond continue to dominate the literature, cross-case comparative analysis began to contribute to our knowledge. Valuable work now led by Paolo Spada (2017), building on initial data collections from Ana Clara Torres Ribeiro and Grazia de Grazia (2003), and Leonardo Avritzer and Brian Wampler (2005), has collected a census of PB in Brazil. Data begins in 1989, with a new wave of data collection in swing as I write. It shows that if survival of PB is a good indicator of its success, then the data is sobering – on average half the processes are discontinued within four years of inception (Spada and Ryan, 2017: 772). But that is getting ahead of the story. PB has now accumulated several good in-depth small-N case comparisons.

William Nylen (2003b) was early to identify the need for research to attend to 'failed' cases. He provides an in-depth account and compares two cases in the state of Minas Gerais – Betim and João Monlevade – where the PT was voted out of office following a clear opposition mandate to remove all traces of such participatory programmes (2003b: 96). Nylen contrasts the overt mobilization of *petistas* (affiliates or supporters of PT) at the expense of working with existing neighbourhood associations in João Monlevade's first short-lived PT administration, with subsequent conscious efforts to avoid partisan mobilization in Betim's PB.

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Although the PT survived an extra term in Betim, the result – an end to PT rule and to participatory programmes in the face of fierce political competition – was not averted. In both cases Nylen reports that a strong and sometimes violent opposition were able to recast PB as partisan and inefficient regardless of the PT's efforts. Despite the variance in effort, the result was the same. Based on Mill's principle of agreement we can discard these active efforts to avoid partisanship by a ruling party instigating PB as a sufficient condition for enduring change. An all too often ignored strength of these simple comparative techniques in the empirical social sciences is the potential to discount factors that might be theorized to be relevant to an explanation. The PT in Betim may have thought they were learning lessons from João Monlevade, but a less partisan approach to PB when implemented in a relatively similar context was not enough to help them. The question of how to develop open participation in the face of entrenched partisanship crops up again and again in reviewing the cases of PB, and it is one for which there appears to be no simple answer.

The selection of these cases also exploits the logic of the method of difference, in that these are 'failed' cases where the bequest of deepened democratic consciousness that evolved in Porto Alegre was not observed. Extreme forms of clientelism returned.[1] So Nylen also goes some way to providing cumulative evidence for what quality of a potentially important explanatory variable is required for empowered democracy. Regardless of how it is achieved, successful non-partisan mobilization would appear to be a necessary condition for PB flourishing and deeper democratization on the evidence of these three cases. We can combine Nylen's finding with evidence of weak opposition highlighted in the description that Benjamin Goldfrank gives of PB's inception in Porto Alegre (now cumulating knowledge from diverse case studies) to hypothesize that the weak opposition is the context that enables non-partisan mobilization. Thus, we might surmise that when weak opposition is combined with a PT-initiated PB programme, partisan PB that is susceptible to a lack of buy-in from those outside the PT is avoided.

Yet we might know that PB still had good outcomes in the face of strong opposition in some cases – Goldfrank offers the example of the Limatambo district in the Cusco region of the Peruvian Andes (2011: 259–60). On the evidence of all these cases taken together, a weak opposition is an INUS condition (that is an Insufficient

[1] Later work by Baiocchi et al (2011) suggests João Monlevade did achieve a more empowered democracy, but only after the PT returned in 1997.

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but Necessary part of a combination of conditions which is itself Unnecessary but Sufficient) (see Mackie, 1988 : 62), for deepened participatory democracy. We are cumulating and developing cross-case insights, but they are adding up to a mouthful! This is a small insight into the logical thinking of case-based comparative methods. But it is usually too difficult to transfer these comparisons beyond a small number of cases as it becomes too difficult to consider all potential combinations of causal factors in one researcher's head. QCA offers some tools to overcome that problem, as I will show in the chapters that follow.

How variance in design as well as context explains outcomes – comparison within Brazil

Several contributors have offered comparisons that show that explanatory conditions for empowered democracy in PB are rarely a matter of black and white. As with Nylen, Marcelo K. Silva (2003) compares two Brazilian cases – this time on the outskirts of Porto Alegre in the state of Rio Grande do Sul – Alvorada and Gravataí. His focus is on the effect of PB on civil society and his key question is whether a policy innovation from a nearby metropolis works in a similar way in cities with different 'associative environments' (2003: 114). He describes a complex patchwork of both positive and negative and changing relationships between associations and PB in both cases, with engagement from different groups ebbing and flowing. Despite dense networks of neighbourhood associations, those were often characterized by clientelist politics and internal disputes. The support for popular participation characterized by some accounts of the CSOs in Porto Alegre was absent or opposed to a certain degree in some of the CSOs in these cases. Silva provides the salutary lesson that we should not assume that CSOs will necessarily see themselves as carriers of radical democratic norms. The important contribution here is to illustrate that the character of civil society in a municipality cannot easily be dichotomized as supportive or unsupportive of participation in an absolute sense. CSO support for participation is not indeterminate, but it ranges in value where organizations can be both supportive and not supportive to various degrees. That is, cases of PB have fuzzy membership in the set of civil society support for participation.

Another excellent contributor to the development of comparative analysis of democratic innovation is Leonardo Avritzer (2005). Avritzer has described PB in Porto Alegre in conjunction with the process in

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Belo Horizonte. He can show that PB rules can be effectively adapted to new settings, and 'invention' is often conditioned by pre-existing arrangements and cultures of participation and politics (2005: 391). Then, by contrasting trends using individual-level data for the number of participants in Porto Alegre and Belo Horizonte, he expands our understanding of incentives for participation by observing citizen behaviour in response to change. When a new administration was elected in the Belo Horizonte case, participation waned, before waxing again the following year when it had been demonstrated that this new administration was still committed to implementing PB.

Avritzer's work also leads the way in comparing different designs. In earlier work (2002) he compares two participatory publics: PB in Porto Alegre with another participatory innovation in Mexico. This is one of many examples of comparisons across types of democratic innovation. While I focus in this book on comparing PB, my comparison can be seen as a test case for comparisons of greater number of cases within and across types of democratic innovation, and I return to the implications for doing so. In a later work as part of a wider comparison of participatory institutions including health councils and participatory planning (2009), Avritzer compares three participatory budgets – adding the case of São Paulo to Porto Alegre and Belo Horizonte. Of interest here for scholars of democratic innovations is a critique of what he calls Fung and Wright's 'static model' of institutional design for deepening participatory democracy (2009: 63–4). Avritzer points out the methodological disadvantages in early research that considered only the most successful cases. The lack of failed cases is often a function of the stage of phenomenological development where the understanding of what a case is a case of, and hence what constitutes an exceptional or average case, is not self-evident to a scattered, nascent research community. Avritzer does not choose exceptional or failed cases, however, but cases whose redistributive and deliberative outcomes are successful to a matter of degree. He shows that redistributive and deliberative successes in Sao Paulo, an 'almost unsuccessful case' (2009: 115), were tempered by a context in which the potential for a powerful opposing coalition to form was greater than in the other cases, leading the administration to provide alternative avenues for public politics that weakened PB (2009: 113). Where PB has become successful it has often become *the* venue for inclusive democratic policymaking above other competing mechanisms.

Avritzer's critique also rounds on cultural factors. What Fung and Wright overlook is 'the presence of other variables, such as clientelism or party interest. Those more specific variables may

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hinder local participation, even when broad enabling conditions are present' (2009: 63). His warning that cultural variance means that participatory design cannot be a drag-and-drop solution is a sage one. We should expect results to vary with similar designs and democratic deepening to be achieved with different ones. I will also argue in the penultimate section of this chapter that attention to the importance of cultural idiosyncrasies in causal explanation can be as dangerous as it is advantageous.

Avritzer highlights a more fundamental aspect of comparative logic often overlooked by some preferred methods in social science: the relative presence or absence of a single condition in any logically possible conjunction of design and context can fundamentally alter the effect of all other variables on an outcome. His comparison leads him to strongly avow that it is dynamic 'interaction between civil and political society' (2009: 64), where voluntary associations develop participatory mechanisms *and* political actors choose to embed participation in their way of governing that clearly explains successful participatory design. In other words, as is almost always the case in social science, explanations have identifiable but key contingencies, and causation is conjunctural.

Each possible combination of presence or absence of relevant causal conditions – participatory leadership, strength of civil society, relative wealth etc – represents a logicallly unique combination of conditions. Any number of substantive empirical cases may display the same values of presence or absence of conditions at some level of abstraction. For example, we may find Belo Horizonte and Porto Alegre have similar levels of all variables of interest – participatory leadership, strength of civil society, and so on. Also, in social scientific inquiries there are almost always logically possible combinations of conditions for which we have no empirical examples. These are sometimes known as logical remainders, or, more often, counterfactuals. They indicate what we do not know but may need to find out about, or at least make transparent our assumptions about what we think would happen were such conditions to combine. Our agenda as researchers is to iteratively theorize and study the world to fill in these gaps. The comparisons of two or three cases I discussed develop the literature and make important discoveries about what works in PB, hinting at the relevance and irrelevance of potential causal factors. Still, we cannot rely on unconnected small-N comparative designs alone to develop better theories. It is very difficult, if not impossible, for even well-designed comparisons of two to three cases to allow enough variation across key factors. This is even more obvious if we accept that the degree

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of presence of one causal factor may alter the effect of another. So, small-N comparisons should also be cumulated where possible.

More cases, larger-N comparisons

A significant and welcome recent development has seen large-N comparisons of cases of Brazilian PB. Avritzer and Wampler (2005) use descriptive statistics to illustrate the diffusion of PB through Brazil, paying attention to the ideological hue of parties, relative wealth and development, and the size and location of municipalities adopting programmes. They show that there was a general trend to PB adoption by governments further to the ideological right and in less wealthy municipalities over time. They also provide some figures for the number of CSOs across cities implementing PB in the state of Minas Gerais.

In Brazil also, Touchton and Wampler compare larger municipalities where PB was adopted with those where it was not. They find associations between PB adoption and increases in municipal healthcare and sanitation spending, with estimated effects becoming greater over time (2014: 1456). They also find evidence that adopting PB increases the number of CSOs and reduces infant mortality. They provide a nice comparison to try to separate the effects of PT control of the executive from those of PB adoption. While greatest estimated gains are seen in municipalities where PT governments adopted PB, they show that in two out of three cases (healthcare spending and infant mortality) estimates are more attractive for non-PT-led cases of PB than in PT-led municipalities where PB was not adopted. This finding is important because it provides evidence that successful outcomes of governance change associated with PB are not entirely party dependant. Sónia Gonçalves' parallel investigation allows for general corroboration of the findings on living standards between the two studies. Her analysis finds that spending on healthcare and sanitation has an increased effect on reductions in infant and child mortality where PB is adopted, independent of political party and state (2014: 104).

Spada uses sophisticated econometric modelling techniques to compare the effect of introducing PB on city finances and separately on the re-election of the incumbent political party to the mayoral administration (2010). He is one of the first to give a good indication of the effect of implementing PB over time and whether there are lags in its effects. He can show that there is no clear evidence for claims for an improvement in municipal finances in the medium to long term across Brazilian municipalities adopting PB. His second model is equally salutary in that it reorients us towards the realpolitik and potential gains

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at play for parties adopting and discontinuing participatory policies. There is a general trend towards short-term gains for both these actions (with some differences based on size of municipality and ideological hue of party). His work was another serious advancement and perhaps representative of a wave of research that came after the initial positive evaluations to show more mixed outcomes from PB.

Large-N variable-oriented analysis of PB is still relatively nascent in Brazil and elsewhere. I should also clarify that I am principally concerned here with studies where the unit of analysis is the political community in which PB takes place. There are good examples of PB surveys that analyse individual PB participants sometimes across cases (see Wampler and Avritzer, 2004; Ganuza and Francés, 2012), but my analytical focus is not at the individual level. The findings of individual-level surveys can contribute to higher-level comparison by helping to provide evidence to aid measurement of higher-level conditions.

The advantage of large-N analysis is that it allows us, by way of some abstraction in stepping back from the complexity of the case, to ascertain which claims have more general application. Greater accumulation of findings can force us to go back to the cases and think again about which elements of explanations might be more or less relevant in the light of information provided by other cases. For example, reports based on observations of early cases excitedly hypothesized that both electoral and financial reward would accrue for municipalities with PB programmes. Large-N analysis showed a lack of clear evidence for a significant relationship between PB and electoral and financial gain, or that the effect was at best short-lived (Spada, 2010). Nevertheless large-N analysis cannot be a substitute for accounts that establish how combinations of factors manifest within cases and therefore what kinds of abstractions are reasonable. Perhaps the effect of electoral and financial gains is rare but is sustained in specific types of cases, and we can explain the confusion that way. Later reflections on generalizations that jumped the gun may allow those with knowledge of the cases to clarify, for instance, that tax reform and recoupment was an aid to, rather than an outcome of, early PB successes (Baiocchi and Ganuza, 2016; Ganuza and Baiocchi, 2019).

What prospects for a middle way?

Brian Wampler's comparison of eight participatory budgets in Brazil was the first to show the significant possibilities for moving beyond two or three cases while retaining the virtues of holistic case-based complexity in explanations (2007a). He provides a detailed narrative

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of processes within cases, but also systematically selects cases to help in understanding what conditions are necessary and sufficient for a high quality of citizen-led decision-making across cases. Wampler's comparative design again moves beyond best-case examples to include variations in outcome and explanatory conditions. He looks at different design features and capacities and incentives for those who wield power in government and contest power in civil society. In his chapters describing each case, he highlights CSO activity, mayoral support, mayor–legislative relations, the financial basis for implementation of the programme and the 'rules of the game' as influential in determining the depth of democracy coming out of PB processes. In analysing effects, he awards priority to the influence of CSO activity, mayoral support and the rules of the game. He concludes that 'to produce a strong PB programme, it is necessary to have high levels of mayoral support, a civil society that can engage in both cooperation and contestation, and rules that delegate specific types of direct authority to citizens' (2007a: 35).

In a more simplified account towards the end of that book he places emphasis on two explanatory conditions and suggests that mayoral support interacts with CSOs' willingness to use contentious politics to give four very different types of outcomes across which his cases are split. Where there are high qualities of both mayoral support and civil society capacities, as in Porto Alegre and Ipatinga, participatory democracy is institutionalized, whereas when both are absent, participation is emasculated, as in Rio Claro and Blumenau (2007a: 258). Other cases with relatively mixed civil society support differed in type by their mayoral support. In short, Wampler searches for an appropriate parsimony, while taking the likely complexity of causality seriously, and provides the reader with transparency in outlining those decisions. In the following chapters I accumulate research to see if these conclusions hold when we include a wider range of cases in the sample, and outline again transparently the interpretive decisions necessary in doing so. I also show how measurement and coding decisions affect conclusions.

A further sophisticated approach to medium-N comparison comes from Baiocchi, Heller and Silva (2011). They recognize from the outset that the case for participatory democracy, despite much spilt ink, still rests on 'rather fragmented and thin empirical grounds' (2011: 1). While the study design again relies on some rich and demonstrably well-executed fieldwork, the case selection logic applied also adds merit to the study. The researchers apply a matched-pair approach to the selection of cases to increase relevant control and isolate conditions of interest. Their outcome of interest is centred on the changes in civil

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society and its interactions with the state where PB is implemented. Most comparisons discussed up to now have focused on a population of cases where a participatory innovation has already been introduced, basing the case selection decision on variation in outcomes and key causal conditions. Baiocchi et al's design allows them to also ascertain the differences between cases where PB is introduced and similar cases where it was not, controlling for scale, geography and civil society support for the PT.

Baiocchi et al are also able to give us some insight into the variation in democratic mobilization of civil society across their four cases where PB is implemented, renewing discussion of a common theme that variation in the capacity of civil society to act autonomously and contentiously results in different forms of participatory democracies. They find co-optation is more a danger where weak civil society can be observed in combination with an organized top-down process, but also that different kinds of participatory democracy can emerge depending on how governments choose to mobilize or bypass CSOs. These findings bring some nuance to those mentioned earlier. A weak or strong civil society may contribute towards a good outcome or its negation depending on the degree to which other key explanatory conditions (top-down support) are present and how they interact. This multifinality – where the same conditions in a different context can lead to an opposing outcome – is a common occurrence in our simplified theories about the social world. It is one commonly overlooked by some social scientists.

Participatory budgeting and participatory budgeting research move outside Brazil

PB has diffused well beyond Brazil, across Latin America and then to Europe and beyond, roughly in that order. This turns our attention to the question of whether the innovation is indeed one that can be adopted successfully in cross-national contexts. One of the strengths of the comparative studies discussed so far is that they compare only Brazilian cases. Comparative politics was built on the assumption that states vary in numerous important respects. Using the logic of area studies, the authors mentioned previously control for the idiosyncrasies of national culture, political history and institutions of government, ensuring those factors are not determining different outcomes across cases.

One of the first things that those who engage with empirical work beyond Brazil will find is that assumptions about Porto Alegre's exceptionalism can be challenged, if not dispelled. Although

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differences in scale may be a point of enduring argument, similar conditions and outcomes to those in Porto Alegre are found elsewhere (Goldfrank, 2011: 260). Stephanie McNulty's comparison of six Peruvian regions, like Wampler's in Brazil, provides an impressively clear and transparent account based on extensive data collection, and utilizes case selection effectively to make logical inferences (2011). As we might expect, there are historical and cultural differences, as well as variation in state institutions, that have meant that the PB McNulty studies look different to many in Brazil. Despite examples of earlier district-level PB taking place in Peru through the 1990s, she focuses on the period following the initial democratization after the removal of Alberto Fujimori as president. Of interest here is the constitutional reform and General Decentralization Law of 2002 that mandated two participatory institutions be convened at the regional level, one of them PB. This is the first national PB law – although other countries have followed, including the Dominican Republic, Kenya, Indonesia and South Korea (McNulty, 2018: 147) – and in some of those cases guidelines, support, and therefore implementation, varies considerably (see Songmin, 2013; No, 2018). As McNulty explains, unlike the municipal PB more common elsewhere, her cases are regional-level PB covering larger territories in Peru that are quite often difficult for some participants to traverse. Participation is also organized through registered CSOs or 'participating agents' – and the degree to which more loosely organized groups were able to register seems to have had significant explanatory power in determining whether participatory democracy flourished.

McNulty's case selection provides some controls for established geographic differences across Peru. Despite cultural differences, her findings support evidence from previous studies in this alternate context. She shows that 'supportive regional leadership is a necessary factor' (2011: 132) for successful participatory institutions. In these systems, top-level political support appears crucial, and 'no case suggests that the support of lower-level officials can overcome the lack of support by a regional president' (2011: 134). She finds evidence that united and vibrant civil societies in the aftermath, but not necessarily in advance of the reform, led to successes. She also finds that the support of non-elected officials has explanatory power (2011: 133). This last factor is important, because it is often underplayed in theories of democratic deepening.

Staying in Peru, Jaramillo and Wright (2015) have contributed to the large-N studies that emerged in the mid-2010s aimed at associating PB with policy effects. They hypothesize that traditional voluntary

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participatory fora common in Peru, such as the *Mesas de Concertación*, may be better able to produce effective policies than the mandated PB. Their hypothesis is based on observations that the voluntary fora (which tend to be made up of elite interested stakeholders) often have greater access to technical advice through strategic interactions. Their two-wave survey of Peruvian mayors and follow-up interviews in five case studies provides evidence that participatory mechanisms are associated with increased provisions of agricultural services by municipal governments, but that voluntary fora are associated with effective agricultural policies while PB is associated with less effective policies. Their evidence seems to corroborate some of what we have seen in Brazil. They reinforce what is really an age-old lesson in political science – when politicians devolve authority without also providing for the same capabilities and support they themselves would expect when making policy, they are devolving problems and not power.

Before turning to cross-country comparisons, it is worth highlighting that systematic case-oriented comparison of PB within countries is still relatively rare outside Brazil. Along with McNulty's work, Matteo Bassoli's three-case comparison of PB governance in Italy has provided an interesting subnational comparison (2012). Bassoli takes seriously questions around the definition of PB, which I will return to in discussions of operationalization and selection of explanatory conditions for cumulation (see Chapter 4). His focus is considering PB as a type of local governance arrangement. Among European countries Italy has seen some significant diffusion of PB and some of them have had radical ambitions. However, Bassoli provides a fresh note of caution against biases that would restrict PB to an epiphenomenon of a theoretical tradition, and sees it fitting with many existing theories of local governance arrangements (2012: 1185). To understand whether PB is of any worth, we need to keep in mind comparisons with other similar and different modes of innovation and of democratic governance. Within a most-different selection of consolidated Italian cases (based on varying geography, population and the role of the global justice movement in the case), Bassoli shows that democratic outcomes, both good and bad, were generally similar across the cases. This, again, provides evidence for reducing the explanatory importance of geography in our theories. One interesting observation is that in all three cases a clear role for the political opposition within PB was not excessively supported by either the government or opposition, leading to familiar problems for PB itself.

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Gaining early cross-partisan support for PB seems to have long-term benefits. Hollie Russon Gilman provides insights into the starting years of the earliest adopted processes in the US. Gilman's study includes casework in the first US case in Chicago's 49th ward, it's largest case focusing on several New York City (NYC) districts, and a case of youth-focused PB in Boston. Placing these cases side by side, she shows how necessarily different designs targeting different communities have different effects. She shows how some of the democratizing rules applied in Porto Alegre were forgone in Chicago's 49th ward during implementation, often to reflect pragmatic concerns (2016: 40–1). In this PB model budget delegates volunteered but were not elected. On the one hand, this may mean that participants can get involved as much or as little as they like, but it can also produce perceptions of patronage where long-term active 'usual suspects' do not have democratic accountability. Tensions between active members on the organizing committee and other participants developed in Chicago revealing familiar pathologies of small-scale politics (Ryan et al, 2018). Gilman shows that NYC's greater size allowed for greater devolution in roles from the steering committees and also received bipartisan support, giving less scope for perceptions of patronage. Her comparison of districts within NYC also shows differences in bureaucratic buy-in to processes and how conscious choices of organizers affect which communities are mobilized, chiming with her finding that young people had different motivations for attending PB in Boston (2016: 114). She draws a useful theoretical distinction from her empirical work between participants who are motivated by material rewards and those motivated by 'civic rewards' – the feeling of being part of a democratic process.

Larger-N comparisons outside Brazil have also made contributions to general understandings of PB and the life of democratic innovations. In Portugal, Alves and Allegretti (2012) have been among the first to analyse the death and sometimes resurrection of PB in a country that now boasts the largest proportion of voluntary uptake of PB among municipalities (Dias et al, 2018: 259). Later I make the case that considered attention to the bounds of counterfactual analysis, that is, asking what a good representation of a comparator case of 'non-PB' looks like, is one we should not lose sight of. Alves and Allegretti draw a useful distinction between abandonment and 'downgrading' of PB – where, for example, the jurisdiction or resources of the participatory budget shrink but it lives on in a less vibrant form. They offer a novel conceptual categorization and some descriptive statistics covering the 64 cases implemented in Portugal from 2002 to 2012. They report

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a general trend away from consultation to co-decision models in the surviving participatory budgets. Their modest inductive hypothesis is that a more empowered PB that can spend reasonable sums to make changes that matter to citizens is more likely to survive. Lack of staff capacity was also offered as an explanation for disbanding PB in some instances (2012: 13).

Much early work on PB in the English language had roots in Latin American area studies, often motivated by a concern for democratic governance in Latin America. As outlined in Chapter 1, democratic deficits are a concern throughout the 'democratic' world (Pateman, 2012; Stoker, 2017). In what Allegretti and Herzberg (2004) call a 'return of the caravels', PB was introduced from the 'new' world back to the 'old' one. That phenomenon also attracted me to studying democratic innovations. Many still find it hard to accept that radically democratic practices can often live cheek by jowl with radically clientelist ones as countries differently experience the enduring contest between democratic advancement and backsliding.[2] In my conversations with colleagues across the world, I am often struck by how even alleged experts (myself included) make erroneous assumptions based on heuristics about political cultures that they allege are 'uniquely' clientelist or plagued by democratic deficits, when the difference is often far from clear, or at best, a matter of degree. It has motivated my interest in pursuing wider cross-country comparisons despite, or perhaps because of, the warnings that it is a risky endeavour.

Comparing participatory budgeting across cultures

Leonardo Avritzer provides a convincing argument that we ought to be very wary of assumptions that common patterns identified in designs of successful cases should lead to those designs being dragged and dropped without adaptation into other political cultures where broad enabling conditions appear (2009: 63). He shows that even within countries, different cities may benefit from different kinds of

[2] The error in logic is perhaps well encapsulated in an example from UK politics. In 2013, when Raquel Rolnik, UN special investigator on housing, as part of a wide-ranging report, criticized a particularly controversial measure to reduce Housing Benefit in the UK (also known as the 'Bedroom Tax'), a government minister and then chair of the Conservative Party, Grant Shapps, questioned why the UK government should listen to "a woman from Brazil" on the basis that Brazil had a large number of citizens in inadequate housing. I have found this a useful example for teaching students about comparative politics.

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participatory institutions depending on their existing political cultures. Local knowledge for adaptation of successful designs can be key. Nevertheless, over-reliance on that truism can be dangerous if it leads us to think that PB in one context is 'incomparable' with PB in another, as if such a comparison was a fool's errand. Anything can be compared (Ryan, 2016, 2019). Of course, what scholars often mean when they invoke incomparability is that we should not make assumptions that just because something is called PB in one place or claims some effect that it should be considered to have equal effect to the same claim made elsewhere. But to understand veracity of claims and differences in effects we need to go ahead with the comparison, and systematically interrogate and document those differences rather than assume them. Although within-country or within-area work provides advantages in terms of control, these controls can be relied on too much as a logic for excluding cross-country comparisons. Comparison of wildly differing phenomena can be equally instructive (Boswell and Corbett, 2017), and assumptions about what a case is really a case of will often change in the performing of research (Flyvbjerg, 2006).

Yves Sintomer has worked with an amalgam of colleagues over the years to move in the direction of worldwide comparison and categorization of the PB landscape. This is an important body of work. Subnational comparisons and comparative designs that are drawn from an area studies background in Latin America and Europe have a sound methodological basis, but they need to be complemented by cumulative cross-regional findings for an even more ecumenical understanding of PB and participatory democracy. How else can we know and discuss the proper levels to which we can generalize? Carole Pateman considers that given the empirical evidence, 'the problem is no longer whether participatory democracy is feasible', and leaves us with the question as to whether 'in the rich countries, there is any longer either the political culture or the political will to pursue genuine democratization?' (2012: 15). Reflecting on an amalgam of empirical work covering roughly 20 cases in Europe, Sintomer et al do surmise that PB in Europe has 'little in common with the Porto Alegre model' (2015: 165). However, they also suggest some European cases achieve important degrees of improvement in citizen control of democratic decisions. I think Pateman is too quick to draw a line between the desired 'genuine democratization' as it might manifest itself in the so-called advanced economies and elsewhere. Perhaps conditions for participatory democracy may need to be different in these contexts. Only through comparison can we answer those questions.

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Much like some of the work already outlined, Sintomer et al focus on delivering an overview and providing some organizing principles for understanding PB. PB may be a quickly diffusing 'moving target' (Baiocchi et al, 2011: 60), but this kind of work helps us to think about what PB is and what it is not, what the conceptual scope of PB is and what the potential for comparison within that scope might be. One of many interesting analytical contributions of their work so far has been to provide a typology of PB using the logic of Weberian ideal types (see Herzberg, 2011, for a detailed discussion). These are based on differences in design and culture, often on the origins of adoption of the innovation, that lead to differing conditions of deliberation and the role of civil society in PB. These theoretical typologies can offer useful visual aids to help understand what is at stake in PB design (see, for example, Sintomer et al, 2016: 47). Cabannes and Lipietz (2018) provide a similarly useful typological theory focusing on aims of PB. They ask who PB engages, what it engages them about, and which governance logic it applies – whether more radical or technocratic, for example. These approaches are based on inductive category development by scholars who have done impressive work since the early days of PB to keep track of cases as they arise. At points Sintomer et al suggest that there is still too much contrast for systematic comparison and analysis of many different PB types, and they eschew an empirical typology (2013: 11, 20; 2016: 45). Later they call for 'an additional effort in terms of systematic analyses and concept building' to overcome 'flaws in previous assessments and a lack of systematic cross-cutting criteria that would enable those involved to make clear choices in accordance with their margins for manoeuvre' (2016: 164). I will subsequently show that careful analysis of the properties of PB and comparisons that aim for a fully specified typological theory, even if they cannot reach it, can significantly aid judgement and understanding.

There were, indeed, many early attempts to take stock of the diffusion of PB across Latin America and then further afield, first to Europe and then beyond (Allegretti and Herzberg, 2004; Cabannes, 2004; Sintomer et al, 2005; Shah, 2007). While often providing more 'descriptive panorama' (Röcke, 2014: 8) than systematic comparative focus, these works both describe a larger number of cases than before and try and give a first sense of what is at stake in comparing emerging cases across countries with vastly varying political and cultural histories. They draw together many threads of investigation of participatory budgets, and usefully set the parameters for the kinds of questions we might want to ask in a more systematic way, to understand the effects of different combinations of conditions. They give us a sense of the rich complexity

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of the social and political contexts of PB experiments. These have been followed by informative volumes involving ever more scholars and practitioners, countries and cases as PB has diffused (Sintomer et al, 2013, 2016; Dias, 2014, 2018). The most impressive recent contributions are those organized by Nelson Dias and his collaborators. These provide a comprehensive hive mind of global knowledge and experiences of PB, and show that the field is blessed with symbiotic relationships among activists, scholars, critics and do-ers, many of them comfortable in any of those roles. They contain a whistle-stop tour of case studies or overviews of countries or regions from area experts. They are now collecting data for an annual atlas project to map diffusion (Dias et al, 2019). In combining this kind of data with crowdsourcing projects such as Participedia (see participedia.net) (Gastil et al, 2017), there are exciting possibilities for larger-N cross-national analyses emerging. But what of systematic cross-country comparison that explicitly employs case comparison logic for (often modest) inference?

Benjamin Goldfrank has done more than many to advance the cause of cumulating comparative knowledge of PB. In *Deepening Local Democracy in Latin America* he compares budget participation in three cities in different countries: Porto Alegre, Brazil; Montevideo, Uruguay; and the Libertador municipality of Caracas, Venezuela. Left-wing parties promising participatory reform arrived in power in these cases at similar moments, but with varying results. He introduces his work by suggesting that 'the recent boom of studies on participatory local democracy in Latin America has yet to produce compelling cross-national comparative analysis to provide an answer' (2011: 2), and 'causal analysis of why some fail while others succeed remains underdeveloped' (2011: 24). Goldfrank's question parallels the one I wish to answer using a larger number of cases: 'why do participatory experiments aid in deepening democracies in some cities but not in others?' (2011: 2). He attributes the greatest explanatory power for more open and democratically vibrant participation witnessed in Porto Alegre over Montevideo and even more so over Caracas, to greater flexibility in decentralization, and to the weakness of opposition parties. Where municipal governments had jurisdiction to govern over the things people cared about, and where they did not face entrenched and organized opposition to their reforms, they were able to prove the worth of participatory approaches. Both conditions enabled those pushing participatory programmes to achieve their goals. In his conclusion Goldfrank turns to discuss some further examples of what he says are surprisingly successful participatory

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budgets in other contexts in Latin America (2011: 258–60). He eventually shows that despite clear differences in outcomes in his cases, successful democratization through PB has also been characterized by equifinality – the same outcome is reached in different ways elsewhere. This finding is confirmed by further cross-case analysis presented in the following chapters.

It is food for thought that due to selecting a control group of cases where the PT had a small winning or losing margin in the 1996 election (some 10 years after the democratization of Brazil), at least some of the cases discussed by Baiocchi et al in their research (2011) might be assumed to have relatively strongly institutionalized opposition, bringing nuance to Goldfrank's conclusions. Goldfrank might counter that the cross-national nature of his research can show a relative difference in party institutionalization not present in a subnational comparison. And we should not forget that the structure of PB in Brazil has been mostly less formal and less regulated than elsewhere (Goldfrank, 2011: 256). All in all, this points to the necessity of cumulating findings across smaller-N comparisons. Any attempt will at least begin to uncover what comparisons at what levels of abstraction are robust and relevant.

Similar to Goldfrank's systematic small-N comparison of budget participation in cities in Latin America, Julien Talpin (2011) and Anja Röcke (2014) have compared PB across cities in different national contexts within Europe. Talpin's ethnographic comparative approach focuses on how individuals experience PB, and how those experiences are shaped in different environments. It is essential reading for those interested in how shock and shame brought about by some of the mechanisms of participatory engagement affect participation. His engulfment in participant observation in Morsang-sur-Orge in France brings a vivid reminder that behind the scenes of participatory experiments lie politics:

> … several actors are involved in the process, with different motives and dispositions, a complex decision-making process is created, where power is shared by different groups fighting insidiously for it, while pretending to be allied for the common good. (Talpin, 2011: 199)

His comparative approach shows that even in three relatively radical participatory experiments (in their national contexts) the opportunities for participation are conditioned by national and local political norms. Talpin is one of the earliest to provide evidence for the effects of

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participatory innovations like PB on the individual over time focusing on different styles, and in Talpin's cases, 'grammars' of participation.

Talpin finds that variance in participants' prior socialization and the environmental factors that limit or enable their capacity to engage are conditioned by the leading discourses, norms and experiences of disagreement and emotion within the specific participatory programmes of which they take part. Scholars of democratic innovations are still struggling to find methodologies that better understand changes in these variables over time. He repeats an important caution that is subtly present in most accounts of participation – that these instances are a drop in the ocean of any individual's overall political socialization, and we should not expect small instances of participation to mark significant punctuations in long-term individual transformations. In many cases Talpin observes citizens learning how to frame their preferences in the appropriate way to have them recognized, rather than changing their preferences in acceptance of alternative reasons. This is not to say that aggregate change from participation is insignificant, or that learning how to better articulate relatively fixed preferences is necessarily problematic for democrats, but it is to be clear about the potential of PDIs.

Röcke, for her part, finds similarly that national frames have a bearing on how participation is institutionalized. Her methods of data collection are very similar to Talpin's. She takes her case selection in a slightly different direction, choosing a most-different strategy involving the selection of an atypically strong case in one national context, an atypically weak case in another, and a typical PB case in a third. This allows her to provide answers to questions about how country-specific contexts and frames shape the diffusion of PB controlling for positive and negative cases (in terms of typicality and success). Her case-based inductive-comparative approach identifies 'the political will to introduce a new procedure and to support it against administrative and political opposition; administrative support for developing and implementing this procedure; financial means to publicize and organize the procedure; and the type of diffusion', as important factors explaining divergences in processes of implementation of PB (2009: 250).

More recently, Giampaolo Baiocchi and Ernesto Ganuza have been among the first to provide an in-depth side-by-side treatment of two cases in two different global regions (2016). They illustrate two cases that are similar but exceptional within their national contexts – both Córdoba and Chicago's 49th ward represent the first PB cases within Spain and the US respectively. Both cases produce mixed results,

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neither inspiring a transformational popular sovereignty. The authors report curtailment by information asymmetries when experts including both senior activists and technocrats lacked interest in breaking with entrenched roles. But the affinities Baiocchi and Ganuza draw between the cases provide a useful problematization of what we might consider pleasing outcomes of PB. The cases in themselves represent some degree of failure, but for one thing they provided a path to diffusion for more successful cases such as Sevilla and New York in Spain and the US respectively.

Even in their own right the cases opened a space for participation to take root in a way that bettered the politics that had gone before. Baiocchi and Ganuza recall that it was 'actually when participation seemed to break down in moments of ambiguity and indecision that the inquisitive dialogue most prized by democratic theorists emerged' (2016: 138). Their point is that even when participatory budgets are not outright successes on terms many of their participants would recognize, they can, in their praxis of contestation, spark imagination that enables change elsewhere in the political system. Perhaps the point is keenly reflected in the 2019 electoral defeat of Alderman Joe Moore who instigated the PB programme in Chicago and acted as a national and international advocate for PB. The 28-year incumbent was defeated by Maria Hadden, a long-term PB advocate and community organizer. Hadden was originally introduced to PB after responding to a flyer in the 49th ward, and then developed a career of her own in PB advocacy in the US, and later successfully challenged Moore as a disruptor advocating greater transparency in governance. Scholars have assumed – and I have even suggested in Chapter 1 of this book – that successful PB will beget emancipatory successes and that failures may risk disillusion. However, especially when we look back at cases and think of more distal effects, we should remember that there are a lot of possibilities in between.

A final recent evolution in PB comparisons comes from a set of studies that expand the systematic comparison of PB while also comparing other participatory designs. Françoise Montambeault (2016) compares four cities, bringing to the study of PB the novelty of a holistic framework for case comparison including more than one case per country. Two cases of participatory urban planning in Mexico – Ciudad Nezahualcóyotl (Neza) on the outskirts of Mexico city, and León – are compared along with two participatory budgets in Brazil – Recife and Belo Horizonte. Her case selection aims to control for relatively similar shared decentralization and traditions of associationism and clientelism in both countries (2016: 47). Montambeault examines

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cases with different outcomes within the separate participatory programmes that were shaped differently across countries. She can therefore draw associations between success and failure across two different types of PDI. Her approach emphasizes complexity of cases, treating variables – actors, institutions and contexts – as 'not isolated from one another' (2016: 62). An important contribution of her work is to recognize that the concept of 'success' in participatory programmes is under-theorized. She takes on the task more explicitly than most who have gone before, and prefers a conceptualization grounded in a combination of autonomy and collective mobilization.

Casting the net even wider, Geissel and Hess (2017) include evaluations of PB as part of large meta-synthesis aimed at explaining political efficacy arising from participatory programmes in Germany. They show that financial and structural governance support is more important than politicians' ideological commitments in explaining efficacy, and that participatory history within a locality also has strong associations with efficacy. Elsewhere Joan Font and collaborators compare many proposals arising from different participatory processes in Spain, and conclude that proposals that arise from PB when compared with other participatory designs are much less likely to be rejected by policymakers (2017: 269). Some recent studies describing the evolution of PB in Spain since that fieldwork was carried out highlight the influence of political turbulence and digitalization leading to more individualized forms of participation in larger cities adopting forms of PB, often replacing delegated forms of project prioritization and oversight (Francés et al, 2018). It will be interesting if future data collection can ascertain the impact of design change on the outputs of PB.

Towards a systematic cumulated comparison of participatory budgeting

Comparison of participatory budgets has become ever more sophisticated, but its lessons are widely dispersed and not always contemplated together in a holistic and systematic way. In this chapter I have outlined the process of maturation of a new and significant subfield in political studies. The established fields in political studies have always benefited from early conceptual work in organizing their scope and principles (Lijphart, 1971). We are still at a relatively early stage of phenomenological development with democratic innovations. Among those PDIs, PB studies are the most advanced. Iteration among theory-led concept refinement and comparative political science is enabling self-actualization of a field of research. Developments in

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comparison build knowledge and build the field. In simple terms, as Mill's methodological doctrine would have it, 'We compare phenomena with each other to get the conception, and we then compare those and other phenomena with the conception ... the conception becomes a type of comparison' (1950: 298).

An important lesson to take from this story of the development of comparison of PB is that the kinds of questions that are asked by small-N comparativists and the variables they favour investigating seem to differ depending on the cases they select to compare. Campbell et al (2018), using a systematic scoping review, searched 21 electronic databases to identify evaluations of PB with the aim of assessing impacts of PB on health policy. Their work also serves to show the diversity of reporting of different aspects of cases. There is no clear reporting standard for information about cases that has developed. That, I will show, requires some innovation to allow any systematic cumulation. Campbell et al also show a wide range of outcomes investigated, many different analyses strategies and several data collection approaches across the 37 cases they identify where outcomes are evaluated. The vast majority of research that analyses political outcomes (over health, for instance) are case studies (2018: 4–8).

It makes sense when doing in-depth research on a handful of cases to select carefully those cases best positioned to answer a researcher's question of interest. But it is also clear that the choice of cases tends again to constrain the potential for testing the conclusions of one set of cases with another in favour of the potential for 'new' findings. Instead of searching for 'new' findings in 'new' cases, I offer here new and improved findings in existing case research. Let me return, then, to Goldfrank's summation of the state of research on participatory democratic processes: he contends that 'a compelling framework that integrates actors, preconditions, and institutional design remains elusive' (2011: 24–5). My approach in the following chapters is to provide a response to this that is grounded in systematic comparative analysis. Part II of the book takes the reader through that process. The goal is to understand conditions for a deeper empowered democracy by comparing cases systematically, accounting for more than a handful of cases, while retaining quality and complexity.

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